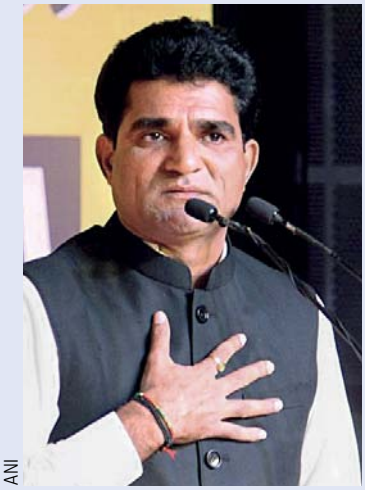


ANI

FROM TV TO POLITICS

The 40-year-old Isudan Gadhvi is a recent convert to politics. He joined AAP in June 2021, leaving his job as an anchor with a regional TV channel. A native of Pipaliya village in Dwarka, Gadhvi is an OBC, but comes from an affluent family. He used to anchor a popular prime-time news show that posed pertinent, tough questions. Gadhvi is a good orator, bringing a son-of-the-soil feel to the AAP campaign, which is otherwise dominated by Kejriwal, Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann and state poll coordinator Raghav Chadha. AAP has taken a calculated risk in announcing its CM candidate, but one that has been applauded as a decisive message from the party. The challenge is that it may alienate Patidar voters, which AAP hopes to counter through fiery state party convenor Gopal Italia, a Patel himself.

AAP'S STAKES

More than the ruling BJP, the party may damage the Congress

SCENARIO 1

AAP gets **7-15% of the vote, picks up 0-5 seats**. The BJP takes a minimal hit while it dents the Congres's chances. Congress vote share of 41.4% in 2017 **is expected to fall to 35% or less**; may lose seats as a result

SCENARIO 2

The Lokniti-CSDS study in October shows that AAP vote share **could even jump to 22%** with a major share culled from the Congress, while the BJP takes a minor hit. **It is likely to displace Congress** as the BJP's prime challenger

the Bharatiya Tribal Party (BTP), considered a strong force in central Gujarat, but the alliance came undone in six months.

If AAP corners an unprecedented 15-22 per cent of the vote: The Lokniti CSDS survey conducted in October 2022 suggests that AAP could get 22 per cent of the vote share, 20 per cent of which might come from the Congress and 2 per cent from the BJP. This could put AAP on the road to replacing the Congress as the prime challenger to the BJP in the future. In Gujarat, the unique phenomenon of differing urban and rural voting patterns continues to play out. The aspirational middle class, concerned about their businesses and safety of women, love the stability promised by the BJP. This is the party's core Hindutva vote bank. In 2017, it won 44 of the 58 urban seats in the four cities—Ahmedabad, Surat, Vadodara and Rajkot. Given the pace of urbanisation, the BJP's expectation is that the rural areas getting incorporated into the urban development schemes will keep on adding to this vote bank. The party won 84 per cent of the seats in six of the eight municipal corporations that went to the polls in February 2021. AAP's 27 seats in the Surat Municipal Corporation had clearly cut into the Congress's Patidar votes, helping the BJP in the urban body election.

An analysis of AAP's promises reveals that the core constituency it is targeting is the middle class residing in 'rurban' areas (geographically contiguous villages with a population of 25,000-50,000). "AAP's guarantees will result in a benefit of Rs 15,000-20,000 every month. For a household with a monthly income of Rs 35,000, you can understand how significant this amount will be," Surat-based AAP spokesperson Yogesh Jadwani points out. Education and unemployment are typical issues in the rurban seats.

Since 2002, the Congress has never lost in 15 seats, while the BJP can boast 31 secure seats in the same period. In 2017, 62 seats had a winning margin of less than 10,000 votes; 34 went to the BJP, 27 to the Congress. These are the seats most susceptible to an upset with the presence of a significant third front. "Seats won with slim margins are mostly semi-urban or rurban seats," says a BJP source who has studied the 2017 results in detail, adding that 45-50 of the total 182 seats would qualify as rurban seats now. According to NITI Aayog's 2021 estimates, Gujarat is the second most urbanised state in the country with 44.5 per cent of the population living in urban areas.

For AAP, its performance in Delhi will find some resonance among urban voters. Its cocky campaigns apart, AAP's overtly Hindu-identifying gestures has the BJP wary (indeed, the former's proposal of printing pictures of Lakshmi and Ganesh on currency notes had the saffron party stumped for a response). But then there's the BJP's other favourite cards, nationalism and invoking a fear of the other. AAP's CM candidate Gadhvi is an OBC from Dwarka (see *From TV to Politics*). It may alienate Patidar voters rallying for firebrand young state convenor Gopal Italia, who has roots in the Patidar reservation movement of 2015, but AAP has gambled on Gadhvi who joined the party in 2021. The Opposition parties keep pointing out how the ruling party has changed three CMs since Modi left for Delhi in 2014; the entire state cabinet was replaced last year.

The problem for BJP and Modi is that the 182 seats in Gujarat mean much more than just winning enough seats to form the government. It's about showcasing the state as an impenetrable party fortress in the lead-up to the 2024 general election, making a mockery of anti-incumbency, grinding the opposition to dust and being the ultimate ornament in Modi's armour of invincibility. ■